

TOP DECK Assam CM Sarma at a rally in Barpeta, March 24

failed to win a single seat. The message was clear: vote share does not translate into seats without alliance backing.

KERALA

Kerala remains an outlier for the BJP, with the party unable to break the tightly structured bipolar contest between the CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF). In 2021, the BJP got 11.4 per cent vote share, but failed to win a single seat. The breakthrough came in 2024, when actor Suresh Gopi won Thrissur, the party's first Lok Sabha victory in the state. Recently, the party also captured the corporation in capital Thiruvananthapuram in the local body polls.

For 2026, the BJP is targeting 15 'winnable' seats in the 140-seat house. It also has some big-ticket candidates, such as ex-Union ministers Rajeev Chandrasekhar and V. Muraleedharan, and former DGP R. Sreelekha. The focus is on constituencies where it polls 15-25 per cent, mostly concentrated in Thiruvananthapuram, Thrissur and Palakkad districts. A key part of this push has been the outreach to the 18 per cent Christian population through engagement with the Syro-Malabar Church and bodies like the Kerala Catholic Bishops' Council. This outreach has backing at the highest level, with PM Modi himself meeting Church leaders in November last and again recently.

Yet, the returns remain limited. Christian voters continue to be anchored within the LDF-UDF framework, reinforced by parish networks and long-standing political alignments. The BJP's booth-level machinery also lags behind the grassroots organisation of both fronts. In a state with 75 per cent-plus voter turnout and entrenched voting patterns, the organisational gap becomes decisive.

PUDUCHERRY

The former French colony has an outsize influence in the saffron scheme of things, thanks to the NDA government in the Union Territory. The administration here was led by the All India N.R. Congress (AINRC), with the BJP the other major partner. The alliance continues, with the AINRC contesting 16 seats, and the BJP 10—one more than last time—for the 30-seat assembly. The other four seats have been divided between the AIADMK and the Lakshia Jananayaga Katchi.

Here, too, it's all about incremental gains for the party. It became a serious player after winning six of the nine seats it contested in 2021, and has now relegated the AIADMK to a marginal role in the NDA. There seems to be no downside in Puducherry for a party that established a mainstream presence here just a few years ago, and that too with a clutch of turncoats from the other parties. ■

